

AP

them to do certain things in certain situations.

Many political analysts feel the seeds of an eventual split between the military and Imran were sown at the very inception of this "hybrid regime". Inevitably, they point out, PMs thus installed begin to have delusions of grandeur and think they have actual power to assert themselves. Both Mohammad Khan Junejo under Gen. Zia-ul-Haq and Nawaz Sharif in his first tenure came to power on the shoulders of the military and were sent packing when they got too big for their borrowed boots.

In fact, the kind of fulsome backing Imran received from the army as prime minister may have been part of the reason for his eventual downfall. Even as cricket captain, Imran was known to have cultivated an arrogant aloofness. But what may work in cricket may not necessarily work in government: Imran became alienated from many of his party members and allies, interacting with a small kitchen cabinet of close friends.

In a surprisingly harsh television interview at the beginning of the recent political crisis, one of Imran's main allies, Chaudhry Pervaiz Elahi—leader of the Pakistan Muslim League-Quaid (PML-Q) and Speaker of the Punjab Assembly—characterised the PTI's governance failures as flowing from the government "never learning how to walk because you were never put down and others kept changing your nappies". When Elahi was asked why others had stopped changing the nappies, he laughed, saying, "because nappies have also become expensive".

IT'S ALL ABOUT THE ECONOMY

The Imran government's blunders were most visible in the realm of the economy, which the military had primarily installed him to fix. The PTI's inexperience in governance was a factor, as were global crises not of its making, like the Covid pandemic and the rise in prices of oil and shipping. But the PTI exacerbated certain crises and created others.

Imran had promised a 'Naya Pakistan' where 10 million jobs and five million housing units would be provided. Despite much fanfare, they fell well below the targets. The latest Labour Force Survey indicates that so far, 5.5 million new jobs have been created and unemployment stands at 6.3 per cent, up from 5.8 per cent in 2018. In fact, unemployment rates rose everywhere during the PTI's tenure. The one place they declined was in Sindh province, where it was not in power. The highest unemployment rate—8.8 per cent—is in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, where the PTI has been in power since 2013.

WHILE IMRAN WAS A GREAT CRICKET CAPTAIN, COALITION POLITICS NEEDS DIFFERENT SKILL SETS AND HE WAS FOUND WANTING, ALIENATING HIMSELF FROM ALLIES AND PARTY MEMBERS